

consists of everything you can provide to the creditors to enlist their support and cooperation during the delinquency period. Normally, you will want to send them three things:

1. A hardship letter (see Chapter 1)
2. A copy of your budget (see Chapter 2)
3. Any other supporting documentation they may need

If you don't have any luck on your own, consider seeing a specialist. It's usually worth the visit to meet with a nonprofit credit counseling agency (see Appendix) who can give you an unbiased opinion as to whether you can avoid bankruptcy. Usually this visit is free of charge or costs a nominal fee.

If after analyzing and making adjustments to your budget the credit counselor feels you have the capacity to pay off your debts, they will negotiate with your creditors for you. They may succeed in getting your payments down to a level you can handle. This reduction is possible because many creditors cooperate by reducing or eliminating finance charges. Ultimately, it is in the creditors' best interest to work with you because they get nothing if you file for bankruptcy.

One prerequisite to starting a repayment plan with a credit counseling agency is that they will require you to close your current credit accounts. Some offices cut up your credit cards on the spot. This experience can prove quite traumatic, but necessary, if you are used to relying on your credit cards as money. If you are serious about getting out of debt, you can't keep adding to your debt.

In Quinton's case, he did not visit a credit counselor before filing bankruptcy. He filed before the new Bankruptcy Reform Law went into effect that would have required a conversation with an approved credit counseling agency. After swallowing his pride, Quinton returned to being a waiter. He lost his new car, moved back into his old neighborhood, and started eating

